WHAT AILS THE PARTY

- The Congress is now largely confined to the South, reinforcing its image in the Hindi belt as a regional party
- The perception of it being a "party for Muslims" has become electorally costly. In four of the five states with the highest Muslim share, BJP+ rules on the back of Hindu consolidation
- Nobody knows who decides what. Party president Mallikarjun Kharge and the Gandhis intervene selectively, general secretary K.C. Venugopal takes most organisational calls by default
- The party delays decisions until they become crises—from the tussle for Kerala chief ministership to Gaurav Gogoi's delayed Assam elevation
- There is little accountability. Bihar was lost last year, yet no structured review has been done. Failure carries no penalty
- Rahul Gandhi sets political narratives but avoids electoral management; nor does he empower others to act

hanging fruit because anti-incumbency against the BJP is high, Harish Rawat remains the Congress leader with the best approval ratings, yet Rahul has not met him in two years.

The Rahul Paradox

With power still largely vested in the Gandhi family, many Congress leaders want Rahul to fast-track decisions instead of leaving them to Venugopal or Kharge. One leader says Rahul's approach swings sharply: at times, he appears eager to drive change; at others, he procrastinates, costing the party valuable time. A general secretary in-charge says Rahul replies to messages within 20 minutes and moves quickly when decisions do not require the party machinery. But once the organisation is involved, he tends to wait for consensus. A leader cites an example from the summer of 2025, when Rahul, having just moved into his bungalow as leader of the Opposition, was discussing where to hang a painting as Venugopal walked in to discuss appointing a new Congress chief for a key western state. Rahul initially approved the suggestion with a casual "Yes, yes, do it", but then asked Venugopal to consult state leaders and obtain Kharge's approval as well.

Political scientist Rahul Verma says the Congress's challenge is to reimagine secular-plural politics for an India where majoritarian sentiment has become a potent electoral force

Rahul's supporters describe this as decentralisation. Critics within the party see it differently. No organisation, one leader says, functions through pure decentralisation unless the top leader is an obsessive micromanager or someone below is fully empowered to act. Rahul, he argues, does neither.

Instead, he enjoys shaping narratives—from the caste census to the Great Nicobar issue—but avoids electoral mechanics: candidates, strategy, resources and mobilisation. "Rahul is not a political animal in the conventional Indian sense," says one senior leader. "He is not thinking 24x7 about who to send where, who to remove, who to instal." Elections, the leader says, do not excite Rahul; he would rather read a book or meet and discuss geopolitics with international figures.

On narrative and ideology too, the party appears heavy-footed. Several Congress leaders point to growing online anger against Prime Minister Narendra Modi after economic strain linked to the US-Iran war. They say the resentment is concentrated among middle-class voters, driven by fuel prices, economic stress and governance fatigue. Yet this is also the segment the Congress has virtually forgotten. Its focus remains on the bottom of the pyramid, but that support does not consolidate quickly. One leader from south India notes that the party has lost 90 per cent of Dalit seats since Kharge, himself a Dalit, became president. Meanwhile, Shashi Tharoor and Sachin Pilot—the party's two faces who appeal to the middle class—remain sidelined or underused.

Verma argues the Congress cannot resolve its crisis through short-term gestures such as yatras, temple visits or calibrated messaging. Its deeper challenge is to reimagine secular-plural politics for an India where majoritarian sentiment has become a potent electoral force that cannot be dismissed merely as prejudice. To recover, he says, the party must understand why that sentiment has grown, what anxieties drive it and where its own secular tradition has failed. Without that rethinking, symbolic gestures will not change the arithmetic.

The Congress crisis, then, is not only about leadership, ideology, alliances or Hindu-Muslim perceptions. It is about the absence of an operating centre that can turn intent into execution. Rahul has given the party themes, but themes do not select candidates, settle factions, review states, move resources or build winning campaigns. Unless the Congress decides that who decides—and decides quickly—May 4 may prove not the floor from which it rises, but the ceiling it cannot cross. ■